





guano humble the proud portraits, now lying broken. Usually, such a textbook picture of decrepitude—of Time laying waste to human grandeur—comes to us as a tale of royal hubris. In this little godforsaken patch, however, the crime was committed by the entity that took over from the rajas: the State.

No ordinary crime either. It was committed, in broad daylight, for a great part of 37 years. In 1987, upon the death of its last titular head, Raja Bahadur Sardar Singh, the Rajasthan government took possession of the half-a-dozen properties of the Khetri estate. Acting on a complaint that the estate manager and staff were carting away antiques by the truckloads, it invoked the Escheats law of 1956, the instrument of seizure used when a property has no heirs. Perhaps well-intentioned, but not entirely watertight in this case—there was a will, naming the charitable Khetri Trust as the sole heir, with about seven other self-styled heirs crowding the frame. More egregiously, the government proved far less enthusiastic about taking care of things as it was about taking possession of them. Because the dispossessed went to court, it chose not to spend a paisa on protecting Khetri's heritage.

Not even on a basic lock and key, so to speak. Instead, it left it to the elements, a rich repast for insect and avian settlers, for pye-dogs and other stray fauna. It now looks like a set for horror movies: ant-hills, termite-eaten wood, putrefied carpets dotted by dog and pigeon carcasses. The pugmarks include human ones—soot-covered terraces recall the fire lit by bacchanalian revellers, graffiti grows like fungus on the walls, and the only cleaning was done by thieves and vandals who stripped these palaces bare. Amid the proliferating cobwebs, there lie the remains of continuous loot. Drawers and cabinets unburdened of their contents, empty miniature frames, walls vacated of trophies, swords and other antiques, all suspected to be sold

HALLS OF SHAME

↘ **Bhopalgarh Fort:** Built by Bhopal Singh in 1765 and one of Rajasthan's top forts, settlers' houses dot its hilly, 60-acre campus. It contains two palaces: Naya Mahal and Moti Mahal. Both lie in ruin

↘ **Naya Mahal:** Built in 1895 by Ajit Singh, with a commanding view of the town below, its pillared halls boasted exquisite Shekhawati frescoes, sculptures and intricately painted mirror-work. Most of it now badly damaged

↘ **Moti Mahal:** Of 18th century vintage, and renovated in 1861, another gem of Shekhawati architecture now left to ruin. Its ceilings, bearing intricate circular brick patterns known as *kharanja*, lie broken and defaced

↘ **Khetri Mahal:** The original 'Wind Palace' built in 1770. A complex, interconnected series of open, colonnaded halls and patios on multiple levels, this was the prototype for Jaipur's Hawa Mahal. The paintings in its interiors, done in natural earth pigments, speak of decades of neglect

↘ **Amar Hall/Sukh Mahal/Jai Niwas Kothi/ Purohitji ki haveli:** Respectively, the durbar hall in the centre of Khetri, the residence of Sardar Singh, of his grandfather Jai Singh, and the site of rituals and religious functions. All stand broken by neglect and vandalism: